where the ball moves more than usual. I was deep in the bush, my shorthand for being psychologically gone.

I went back to my room and lay on the bed, staring at the ceiling in my five-star cell. There, amidst a jumble of images, I acknowledged the magnitude of my mistake nine months earlier, when I'd modified my technique with the intention of enjoying long-term success against Australia. I changed my trigger movements and became very rigid.

I have a lot of movement in my usual technique, with a double backlift. In layman's terms, my hands start the trigger. My feet then move, my weight goes back, and I go back and across towards the stumps. My front leg floats, so that if the ball is short, I have the flexibility to push off it. If the ball is full, I can plant it.

I had developed what I called the Jacques Kallis method, named after the South African all-rounder. Again, in basic terms, that involved pressing forward with my right foot first, before going back and across with my left. I had my bat tucked in very straight and waited for the ball to come. It worked initially. I scored 118 against South Africa in Durban on Boxing Day 2009, and made two centuries, 173 and 109 not out, in my first Test tour as captain, in Bangladesh.

It wasn't pretty, and the results were ugly. By the time I fell into a fitful sleep that Thursday night, I had decided to revert to my old technique. I would play naturally and aggressively. I would not die wondering. I would take quiet inspiration from Paul Collingwood, and his pugnacious innings at Trent Bridge.

There is always one player under pressure for his place in an England batting line-up, and it was Colly's turn in 2008. He had gone twenty-three innings without a Test century and hadn't reached fifty in any form of cricket in that wet summer when he joined Kevin Pietersen at the crease. Michael Vaughan, sitting next to me on the balcony, murmured, 'Fuck me, if Colly gets runs here it will be one of the great achievements.'

Colly ran down the wicket to reach his hundred with a six and was last out for 135 following a brilliant fifth-wicket stand with KP, who succeeded Vaughan as captain in the aftermath of a series defeat clinched by Graeme Smith's retaliatory unbeaten 154. He played forcefully, with the body shape and fluidity that so often signals new-found freedom.

I took note of his resilience in producing the big innings when he needed it most. It chimed with another performance earlier that year, when Andrew